

The Whistleblowers

The 'Feds' vs. The FOIA Bulldog

By Don Ecker

Lee M. Graham may not be someone who many in the UFO field know, but for close to ten years he has been carrying on the fight for an end to UFO secrecy, against the government bureaucracy via the Freedom of Information Act, or FOIA. If it is true that certain ufologists are a thorn in the side of bureaucrats, then because of his relentless pursuit of the UFO truth, Graham must rate as a very sharp dagger.

Graham is a 57-year-old employee of the AeroJet Corporation, with the job title of Electro Mechanical Associate, II. He describes his early years as a period of growing interest not only in UFOs, but also pursuits related to the government's development of high-tech aircraft. Graham's strict fundamentalist Baptist parents strongly discouraged such "outlandish" ideas in their son.

In the mid-1960s, a friend of Graham's showed him a news article

on Senator Barry Goldwater saying he was once refused access to the famous "Blue Room" at Wright Patterson Air Force Base, where hard evidence of UFO-alien reality has been rumored to be housed. Because of his fundamentalist Christian background, Graham says he refused to believe that a secret governmental "UFO room" could be true. So he decided to set out to disprove this allegation.

In 1979, Graham wrote Goldwater, asking him about his allegedly being refused access, and if he believed in UFOs. Goldwater wrote him back, acknowledging the letter and further commenting, "we both know about the rumors."

After the publication of *The Roswell Incident*, detailing a still-renowned UFO crash in 1947, Graham sent another letter to Goldwater, including a photocopied reference to the "Blue Room" from the book. Goldwater responded and

once again stated that he had been refused access to the infamous "Blue Room."

At that point, Graham initiated a petition within Aerojet, which asked for a UFO hearing and that Goldwater be allowed access to the notorious "Blue Room." The petition garnered over 50 signatures. (Goldwater, one of the most powerful U.S. senators and a reserve U.S. Air Force general, had been refused permission into the Blue Room by his friend and then commander at Wright Patterson AFB, General Curtis LeMay. As Graham would later state, rumor had it that Goldwater did finally receive permission.)

Goldwater's admission set the stage for Graham's tenacious pursuit of answers. His story is now taking a slightly different turn, and encompasses a secret spy satellite called the DSP-1, (it may have been used to track UFOs), the F-117A stealth fighter, and an alleged briefing document describing Project AQUARIUS (the nine-page document, not the three-page one which has circulated in the UFO community) that is alleged to have been written to brief incoming President Jimmy Carter on UFO projects in the military.

Alleged 'covert' operation

Most importantly, Graham's self-described saga also involves serious allegations against the U.S. government. He claims that at one point in his ongoing experience, members of the intelligence community set in motion an apparent "covert" operation to pull his security clearance, or to gauge his reaction to being exposed to top-secret "need-to-know only" information.

Other actors in this story include the FBI, an Air Force general, researcher William Moore, the Defense Investigative Service, a bird called Falcon . . .

The roots of Graham's UFO pursuit reach back into the history of the U.S.' advanced weapons systems. Starting in August of 1958, the U.S. Air Force was discussing a project



LEE M. GRAHAM—An abiding interest in high-tech aircraft and his experience with governmental 'games' has fueled a persistent search for the truth, through letters and FOIA requests to governmental agencies.

called Subject 461-L. The idea involved setting in geosynchronous orbit a satellite capable of detecting a launch of a Soviet missile by its rocket exhaust, through infrared detection.

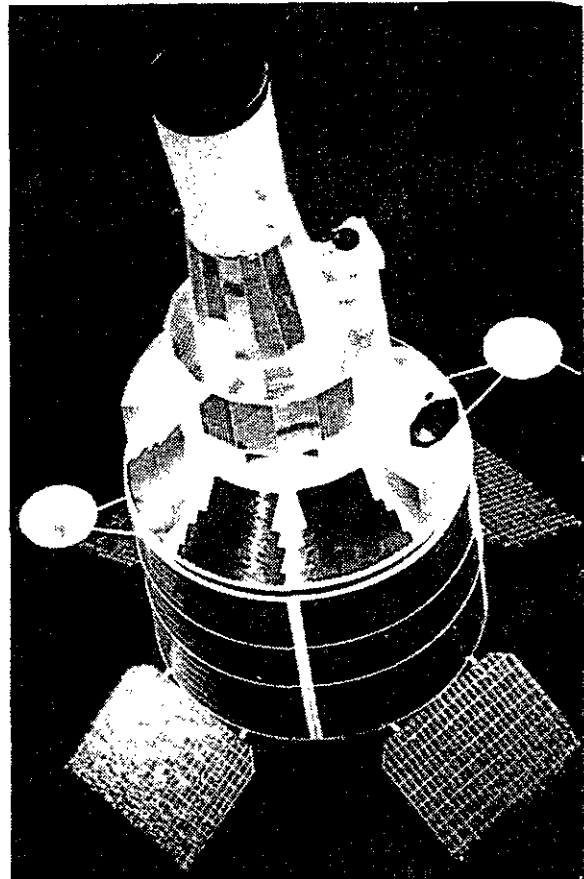
Problems persisted with the program (also called Midas) until about 1971, when Phil Klass wrote an article about the program in *Aviation Week & Space Technology*. Graham, who by then was working at Aerojet, one of the contractors for the satellite detection system, surmised that if this system could detect missile launches or a meteorite, as one report stated, it may be possible that it could also detect UFOs within the atmosphere.

Already having experience using the Freedom of Information Act, more commonly called the FOIA, in 1984 Graham contacted the Air Force with an FOIA request for information on the DSP-1 satellite detection system.



William Moore

"source" had informed him that the satellite identification and detection system was code-named "Tread." Was this code-name correct? Graham sent a letter asking this question of



SPACE-BORNE SENTRY—The DSP (Defense Support Program) satellite uses infrared detectors to sense ballistic missile launches . . . and perhaps, Lee Graham thinks, UFOs.

'You may or may not know that this company, in fact all private organizations, are not governed by the Freedom of Information Act . . . we cannot respond to your inquiry in the manner you wish.'

What Graham hoped to prove was that the DSP-1 had indeed detected UFOs while in flight within the earth's atmosphere. On Aug. 27, 1984, the Dept. of the Air Force Space Command wrote Graham a denial letter citing the "national security" exemption in reference to his request as to whether the satellite detected UFOs.

Graham appealed this action and detailed his reasons; i.e., *Aviation Week* stories detailing the DSP-1 satellite system's capability of tracking objects entering and leaving the earth's atmosphere, an article from *Sky and Telescope* describing a "fireball" passing through the atmosphere, and the Air Force report of tracking the "fireball" with an "Air Force instrument."

Project 'Tread?'

Graham meanwhile had met William L. Moore, the author of *The Roswell Incident* and a researcher claiming inside knowledge of some of the government's alleged UFO intentions. Graham says Moore's

the Air Force Space Command, referring to Moore's alleged source.

The Air Force fired back a second denial. Deputy Administrative Assistant Steven A. Thompson stated, "The existence or non-existence of information responsive to your request is currently properly classified



Phil Klass

pursuant to Executive Order 12356. . . release of the information could cause identifiable damage to the national security." By now, it was 1985. At this point, Graham felt the only tack open was a judicial case, an option which he has always felt is out of his reach.

Refusing to take no for an answer, Graham wrote to Floyd Brown, public information representative for Aerojet Electro Systems, reporting that he had overheard other engineers saying that the satellite system had tracked UFOs "making right hand turns at velocities in excess of 12,000 miles per hour." Once again, Graham received the "brush off," he says. Brown replied, "You may or may not know that this company, in fact all private organizations, are not governed by the Freedom of Information Act . . . as a contractor to the Department of Defense, [we] cannot respond to your inquiry in the manner you wish."

Graham continued to submit FOIA requests to various government agencies. He wrote again to the Dept. of the Air Force on the

DSP-1, and also submitted FOIAs on the then still top-secret stealth fighters.

In February, 1986 the Aerojet Management Club invited Phil Klass, aviation writer and best-known UFO debunker, as a guest speaker for the membership. Graham had corresponded with Klass for several years, and now was meeting him in person. At the meeting, says Graham, he overheard Klass asking several of the members about information on the DSP-1, that at the time could have been classified. Graham stated it was mentioned either by Klass himself or during Klass' introduction, that he was researching a book on the DSP-1. Graham subsequently reported Klass to the Defense Investigative Service for what appeared to be a breach in security measures. But Klass denies having asked anyone for classified information at that function, saying, "I would never have done that, especially with everyone that was there."

Security questioned

However, it was not long after this that Graham's own security classification came under apparent governmental scrutiny. Having come to official attention with his FOIAs (he even provided his security chief at Aerojet with a copy of an alleged government UFO document—to see if it would draw official attention, he claims), Graham was notified that he was being investigated by the DIS as a possible security risk.

Later on, when submitting a FOIA for the file which he knew the government must by now have on him, Graham found out that a "source" in Washington D.C. had spoken to the DIS and referred to Graham as a "UFO kook." Not knowing anyone else in D.C., Graham surmised it was Phil Klass.

When *UFO* contacted Klass, he readily admitted that he had spoken to the DIS. Klass said, "I knew Graham had problems with his clearance because he had written me and told me. I let the DIS know I knew Graham and offered my files to them. I never had any doubt that Graham was a loyal American, but I was afraid that with his obsession with UFOs, a Soviet KGB agent could offer him photos or information of a 'crashed UFO in Russia'

and Graham might be compromised by his interest in UFOs."

Graham was cleared in the subsequent investigation, but a potentially more serious development later occurred. According to Graham, he had become acquainted with John Andrews of Testor Corporation, who is a good friend of Ben Rich of Lockheed Corporation. Lockheed runs the so-called "Skunk Works," purportedly where the company undertakes extensive development and construction of advanced aircraft.

In his conversations with Andrews, Graham's appetite for high-tech aircraft data was whetted. He stated, "Andrews provided me with the designation F-117 and [the stealth project's] code name SENIOR TREND and [convinced me to] make a FOIA for it."

With his beginning inquiries related to secret stealth information, Graham apparently attracted still more official attention—but not ex-

actly the kind he was looking for. It touched off a real story of governmental disinformation, an apparent covert operation involving the FBI and an Air Force general, words from an alleged government liaison called "Falcon," additional DIS investigations, and last but not least, counterintelligence specialists with the Air Force Office of Special Investigations allegedly lying to a U.S. senator—all stemming from Lee M. Graham and his FOIA requests.

NOTE

1. At press time, Graham had not yet furnished *UFO* with copies of his letters to Goldwater.

Did the government in fact try to 'set up' Graham with the intention of ultimately pulling his security clearance? He thinks so. In the next issue, UFO talks to officials and others involved in Graham's continuing pursuits.

Lazar's W-2 In Question

Alleged former physicist Robert Lazar is now known worldwide because of his claimed employment at the notorious super-secret site S-4, on the Nellis Test Range in Nevada, where he says he witnessed and briefly worked on the alien saucers the military has in its possession.

Without comment, *UFO* ran a copy of the W-2 form that Lazar furnished (Vol. 6, No. 2) as proof of his employment claim. The W-2's heading of "United States Department of Naval Intelligence" raised questions concerning the existence of such a department, or at least one with that name.

Researcher William Moore's Fair Witness Project Inc., has run several articles which pointed out areas that deserved further study. Lazar has been difficult to deal with concerning these matters, but events place him and his allegations under scrutiny. Gene Huff, Lazar's good friend, tried to help in getting the story told.

However, there is one other individual who has carried the controversy to the government itself, researcher John Andrews.

Andrews faxed *UFO* a series of FOIA requests and answers that he received from the U. S. Navy. Andrews stated in one letter, "The Naval Investigative Service Command has full power to range across the U.S. Navy," and later he requested, "Confirm the authenticity of the W-2 or state in a signed letter it is bogus."

The Navy did neither. In one of their answers to Andrews, they did state, however, "... results of this search indicated that there is no taxpayer, agency, or other employer with this EIN. Further, we understand that there is no practical method of determining whether the U.S. Department of Naval Intelligence or other employer once had this [Employer Identification Number]." Andrews fired back, "Someone is lying. Plain and simple. The question is who and not if. And I already know the why."

UFO has several phone calls in to Lazar requesting his update on the W-2 controversy. At press time, he had not returned the calls. —Don Ecker